

09

The KIA against the French

The classical home of the system: e5, queenside counterplay, and Black's freeing ...f6 break.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will have a complete strategic map for the French KIA and understand the race between White's king attack and Black's queenside play.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 049 | PAGE 4

Decode: The main French KIA tabiya*The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.*

LESSON 050 | PAGE 8

Play: The main French KIA tabiya*The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.*

LESSON 051 | PAGE 12

Decode: Black's queenside expansion*Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.*

LESSON 052 | PAGE 16

Play: Black's queenside expansion*Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.*

LESSON 053 | PAGE 20

Decode: The ...f6 counterbreak*When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.*

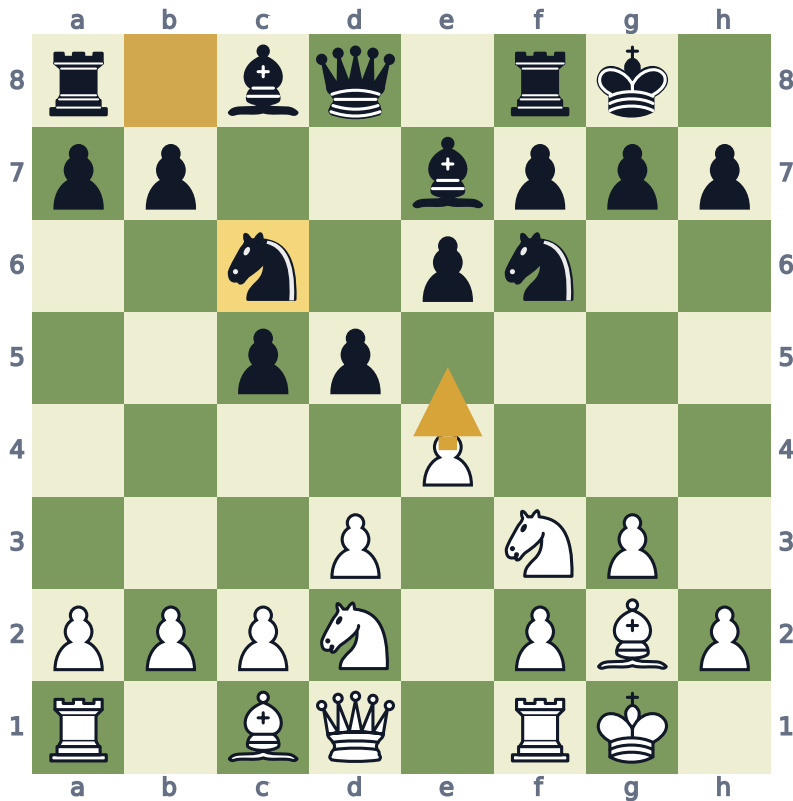
LESSON 054 | PAGE 24

Play: The ...f6 counterbreak*When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will have a complete strategic map for the French KIA and understand the race between White's king attack and Black's queenside play.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The main French KIA tabiya



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

DECISION RULE

Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black expands with ...b5-b4, attacks d3, and times ...f6 to destroy e5 before White's pieces surround the king.

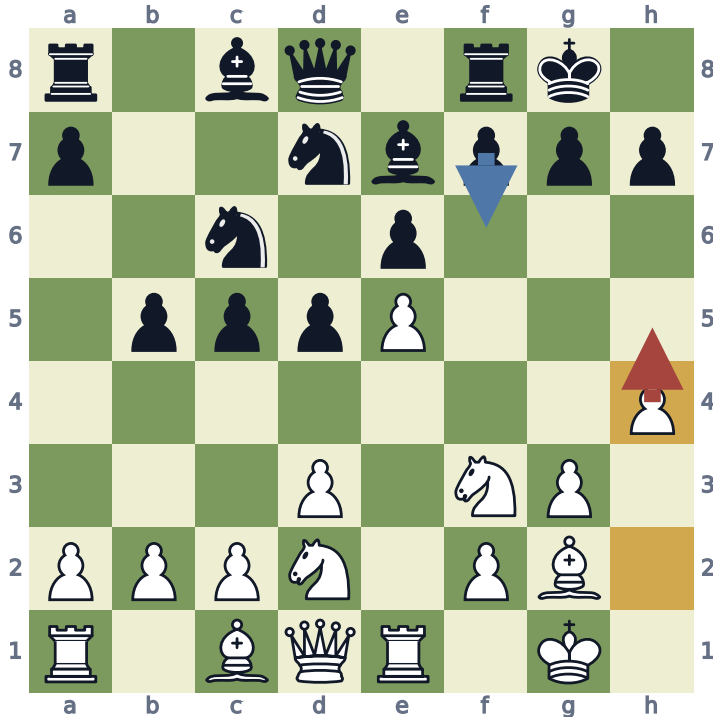
WHITE'S PLAN

White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6.

MEMORY RULE | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black expands with ...b5-b4, attacks d3, and times ...f6 to destroy e5 before White's pieces surround the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming the kingside attack is automatically faster because the black king is the visible target.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

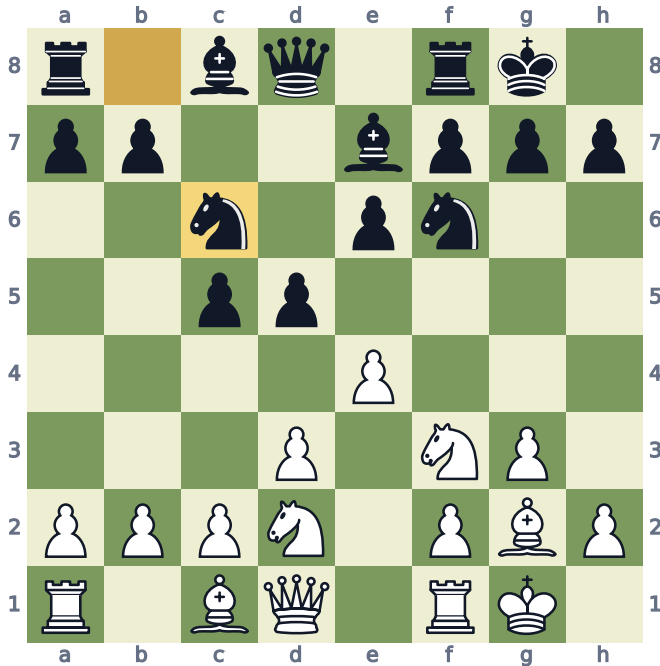
RULE | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4



- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5? White's attacking or positional plan is: White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the kingside attack is automatically faster because the black king is the visible target.

STORE THIS | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

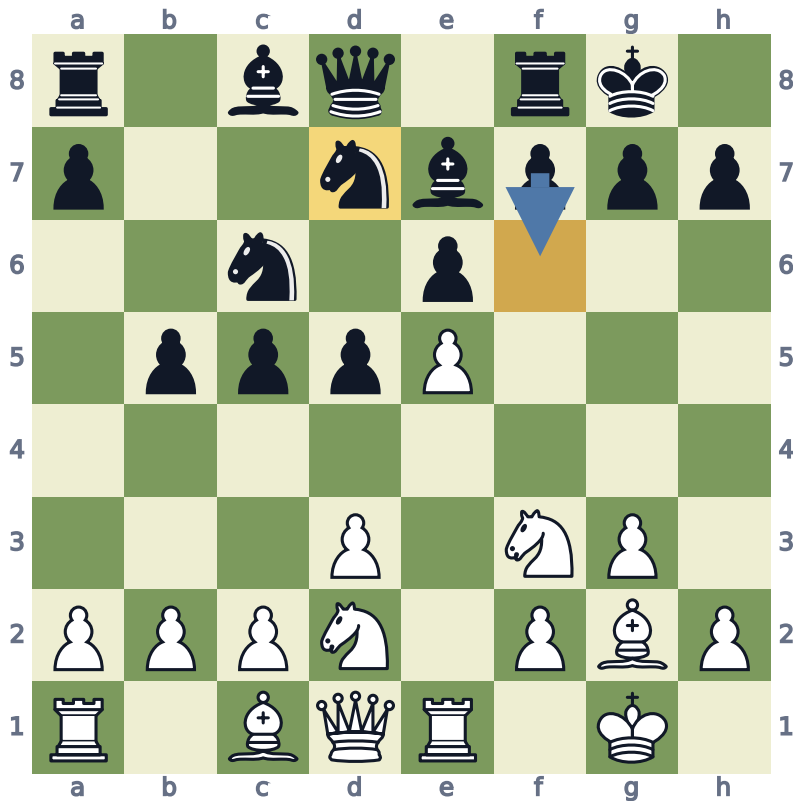
1. The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break. 2. Black expands with ...b5-b4, attacks d3, and times ...f6 to destroy e5 before White's pieces surround the king. 3. White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6. 4. Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5? 5. Assuming the kingside attack is automatically faster because the black king is the visible target.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The main French KIA tabiya



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

DECISION RULE

Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black expands with ...b5-b4, attacks d3, and times ...f6 to destroy e5 before White's pieces surround the king.

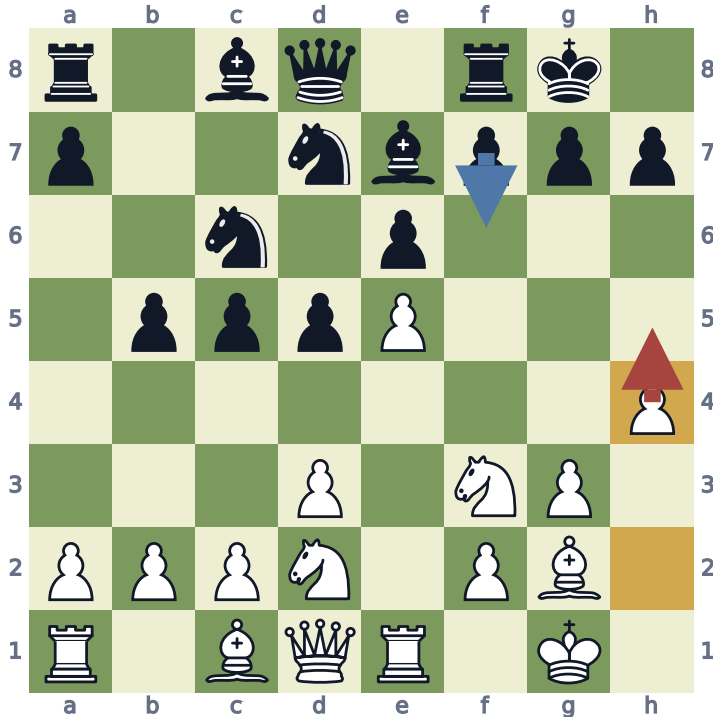
WHITE'S PLAN

White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6.

MEMORY RULE | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black expands with ...b5-b4, attacks d3, and times ...f6 to destroy e5 before White's pieces surround the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming the kingside attack is automatically faster because the black king is the visible target.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

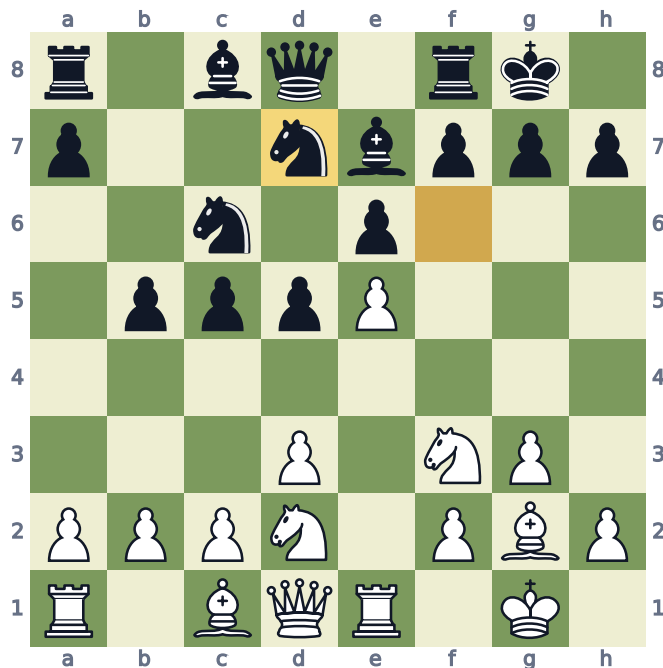
RULE | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The French KIA gives White a familiar kingside space wedge while Black receives a large queenside and the thematic ...f6 break.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5? White's attacking or positional plan is: White completes Nf1-h2-g4, Bf4, and h5 while monitoring the speed and tactical effect of ...f6. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the kingside attack is automatically faster because the black king is the visible target.

STORE THIS | The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

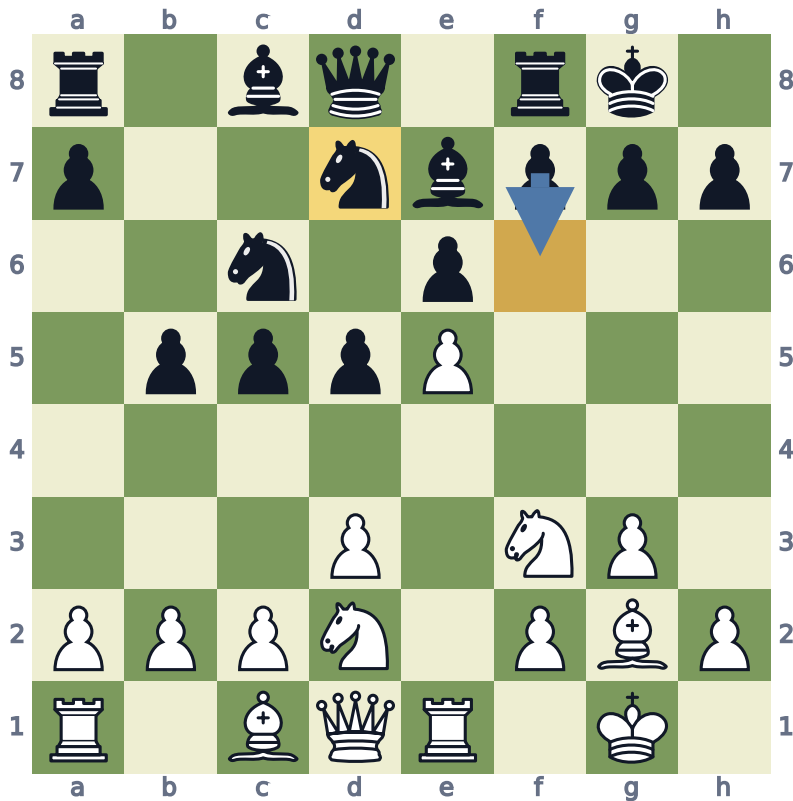
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Black's queenside expansion



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

DECISION RULE

Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses each pawn move to gain a tempo or create a file and avoids overextension that gives White a central break.

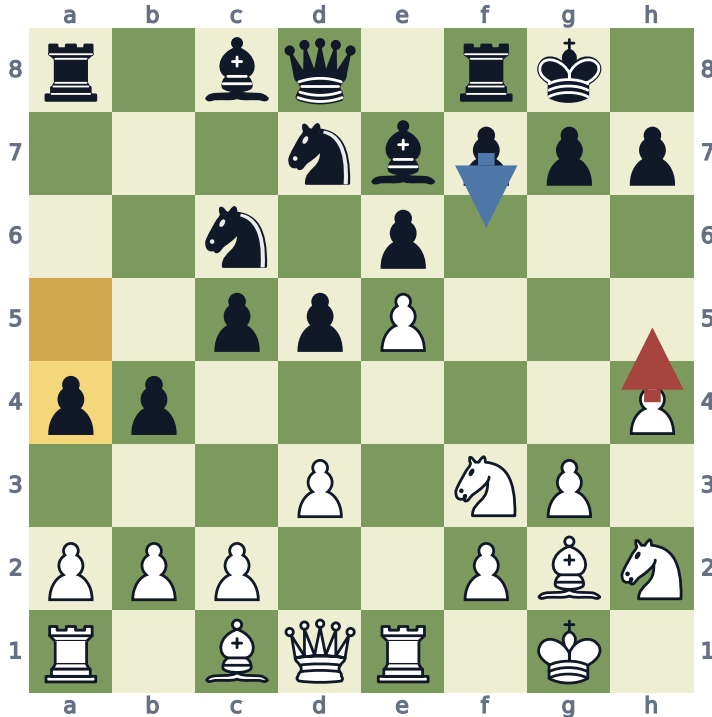
WHITE'S PLAN

White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses.

MEMORY RULE | Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black uses each pawn move to gain a tempo or create a file and avoids overextension that gives White a central break.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses.

FAILURE MODE

Reacting to every queenside pawn move and never completing White's own forcing plan.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

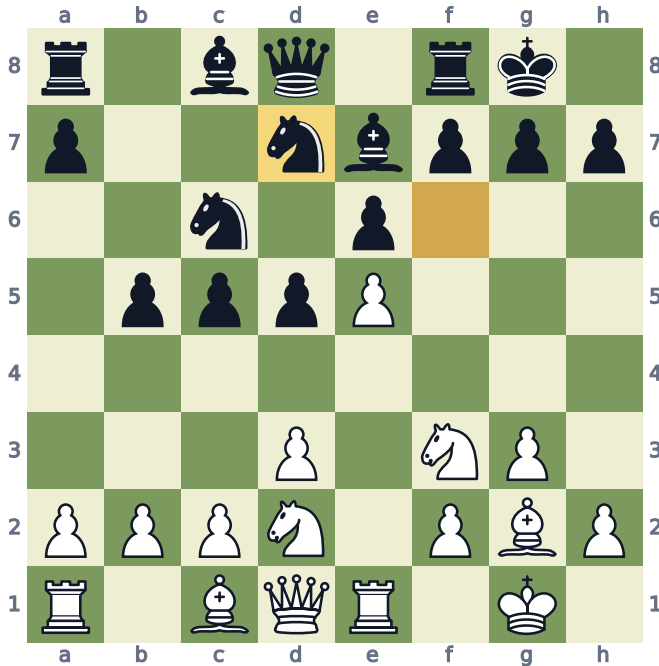
RULE | Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. N1h2 a4



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack? White's attacking or positional plan is: White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses. The line fails as a template when: Reacting to every queenside pawn move and never completing White's own forcing plan.

STORE THIS | Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

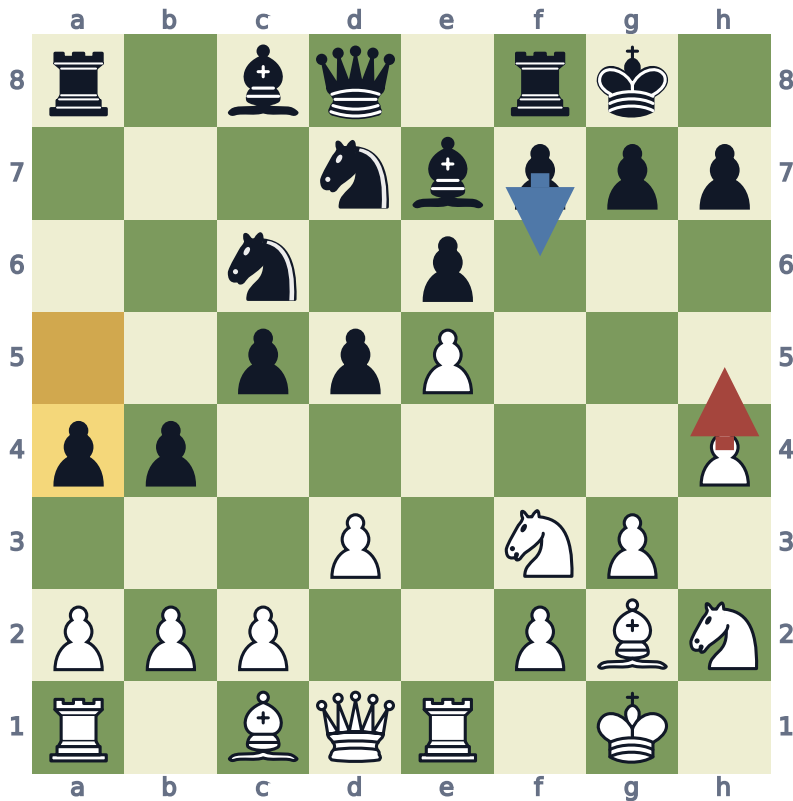
1. Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands. 2. Black uses each pawn move to gain a tempo or create a file and avoids overextension that gives White a central break. 3. White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses. 4. Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack? 5. Reacting to every queenside pawn move and never completing White's own forcing plan.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Black's queenside expansion



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

DECISION RULE

Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses each pawn move to gain a tempo or create a file and avoids overextension that gives White a central break.

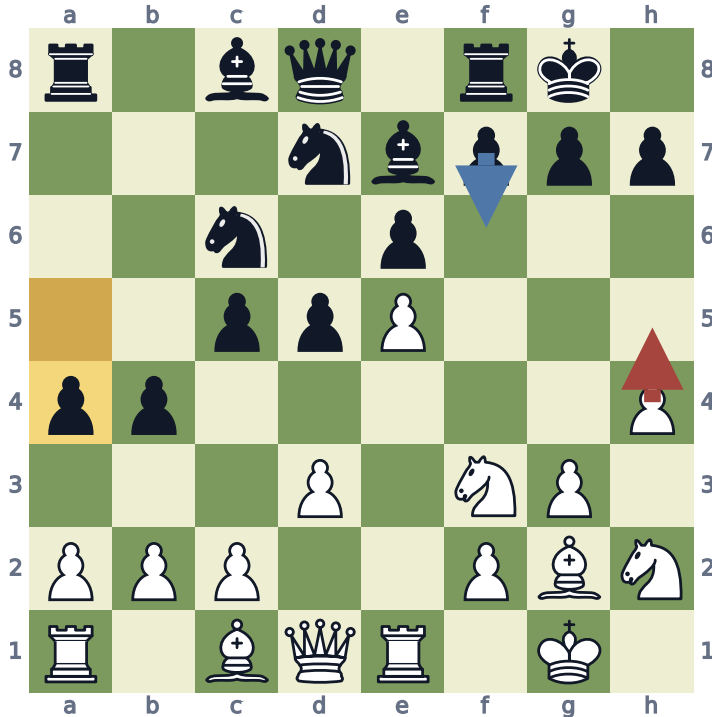
WHITE'S PLAN

White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses.

MEMORY RULE | Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black uses each pawn move to gain a tempo or create a file and avoids overextension that gives White a central break.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses.

FAILURE MODE

Reacting to every queenside pawn move and never completing White's own forcing plan.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

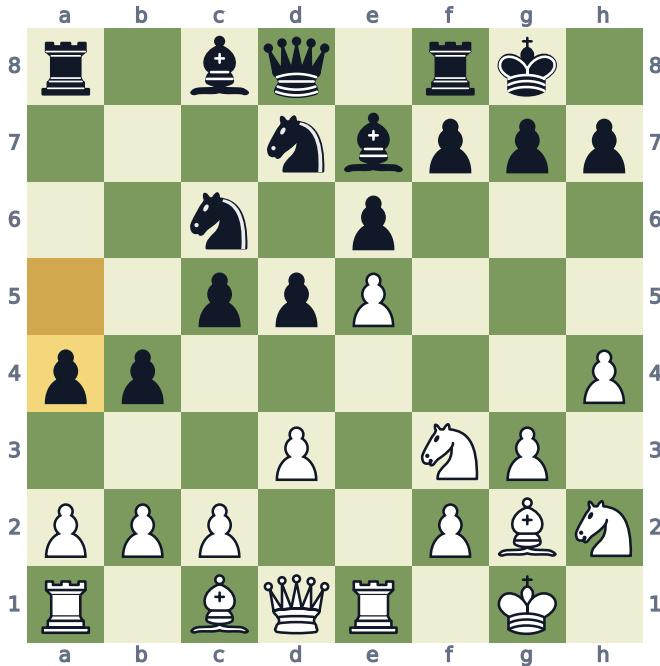
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. N1h2 a4



- h4: White creates a possible kingside hook and supports h5.
- a5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- N1h2: White reroutes a knight to h2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- a4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's ...b5-b4 and ...a5-a4 gain space, attack c3 or d3, and may open files against White's queen before the kingside attack lands.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack? White's attacking or positional plan is: White decides whether to ignore, restrain with a3 or c3, or open the center so the queenside pawns become weaknesses. The line fails as a template when: Reacting to every queenside pawn move and never completing White's own forcing plan.

STORE THIS | Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

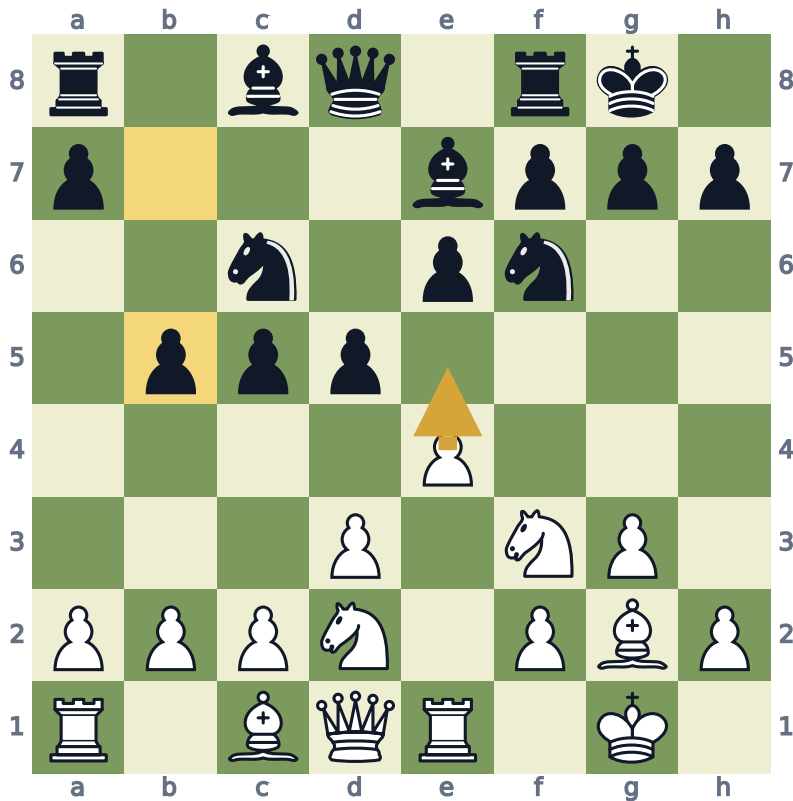
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 24 plies from memory, then replay: 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. N1h2 a4

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The ...f6 counterbreak



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

DECISION RULE

After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king.

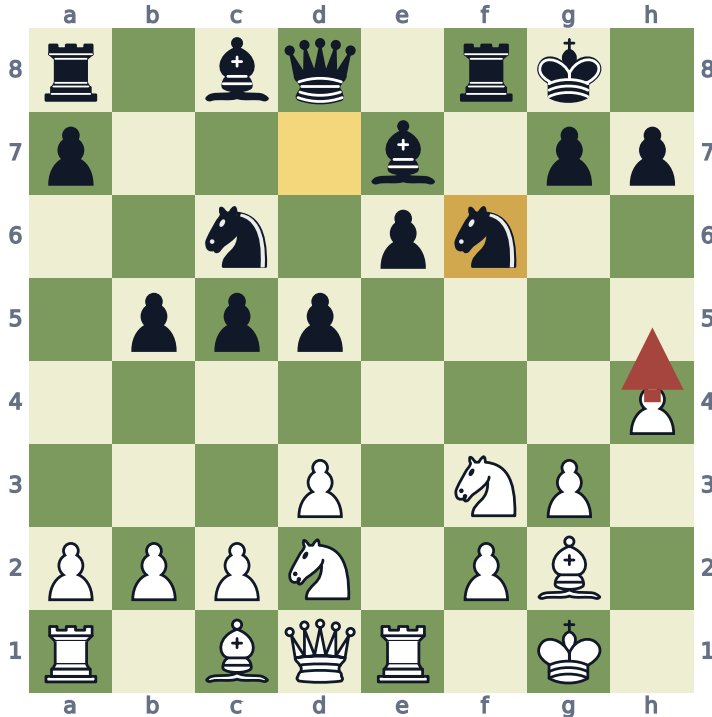
WHITE'S PLAN

White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack.

MEMORY RULE | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack.

FAILURE MODE

Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

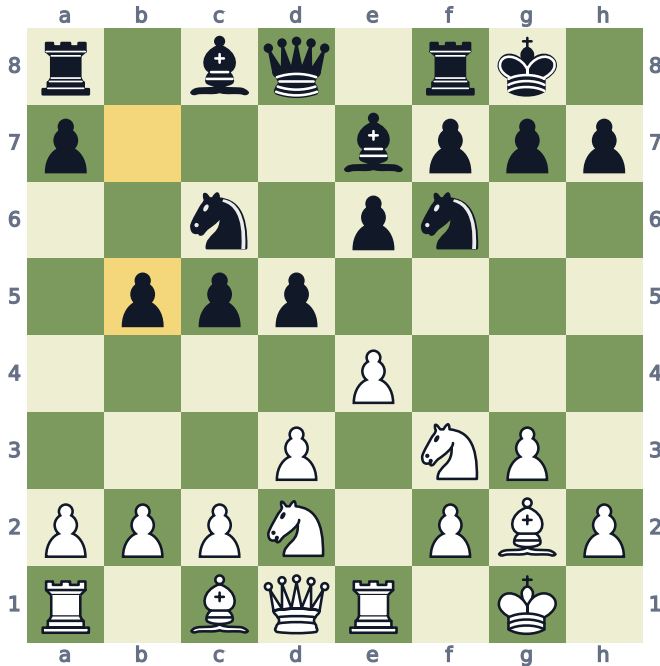
RULE | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? White's attacking or positional plan is: White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack. The line fails as a template when: Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

STORE THIS | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

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ANSWER KEY

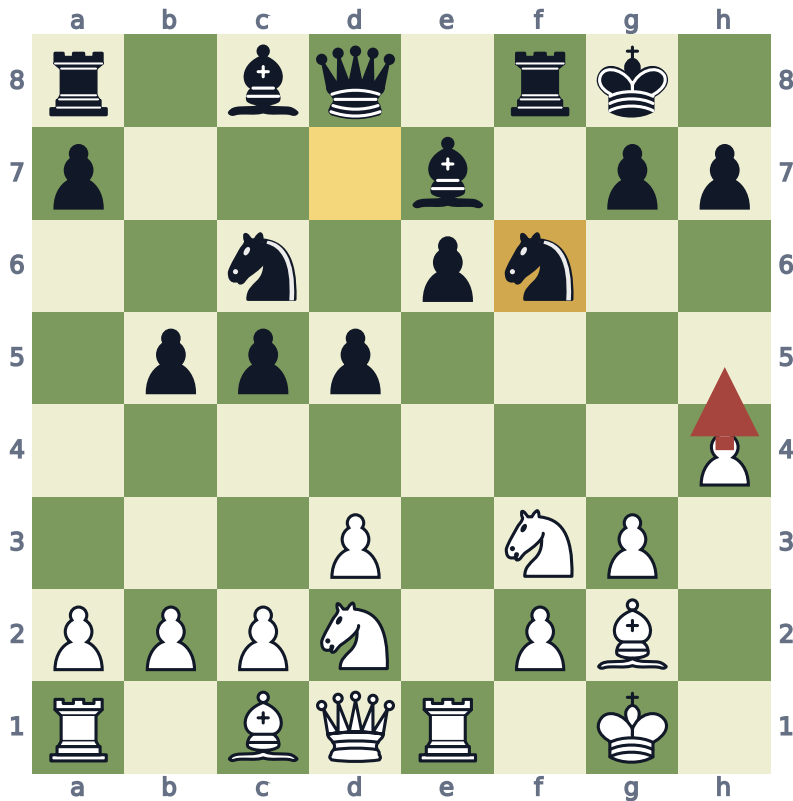
1. ...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer. 2. Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king. 3. White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack. 4. After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? 5. Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The ...f6 counterbreak



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

DECISION RULE

After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king.

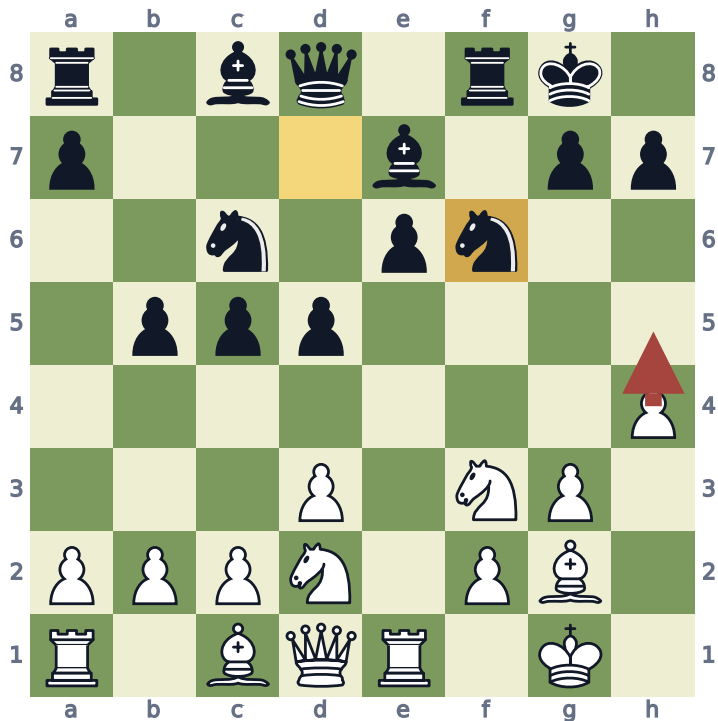
WHITE'S PLAN

White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack.

MEMORY RULE | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack.

FAILURE MODE

Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

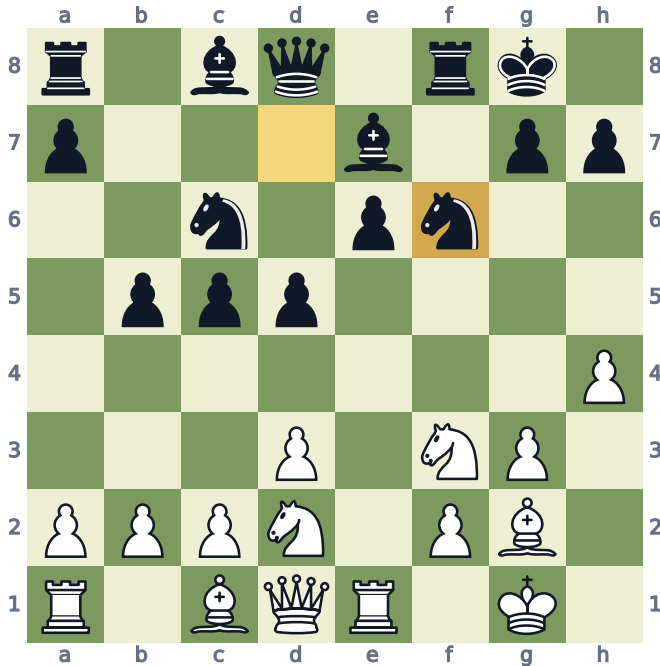
RULE | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 f6 11. exf6 Nxf6



- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- h4: White creates a possible kingside hook and supports h5.
- f6: Black strikes at the head of White's e5 pawn chain and opens tactical lines.
- exf6: White releases tension on f6; recalculate the pawn chain, open files, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxf6: Black releases tension on f6; recalculate the pawn chain, open files, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? White's attacking or positional plan is: White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack. The line fails as a template when: Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

STORE THIS | When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. ...f6 attacks the head of White's chain and opens the f-file, e6 square, and diagonal structure; it is Black's main strategic equalizer. 2. Black prepares the break so the recapture develops a piece and the opened lines do not expose the king. 3. White chooses exf6, a tactical e6 advance, or support of e5 based on which files and squares benefit the attack. 4. After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed? 5. Keeping the e5 pawn at any cost while the rest of White's position becomes tied to its defense.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 f6 11. exf6 Nxf6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 049 Decode: The main French KIA tabiya

Prompt: Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5?

Recall: The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

LESSON 050 Play: The main French KIA tabiya

Prompt: Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5?

Recall: The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

LESSON 051 Decode: Black's queenside expansion

Prompt: Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack?

Recall: Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

LESSON 052 Play: Black's queenside expansion

Prompt: Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack?

Recall: Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

LESSON 053 Decode: The ...f6 counterbreak

Prompt: After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed?

Recall: When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

LESSON 054 Play: The ...f6 counterbreak

Prompt: After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed?

Recall: When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The main French KIA tabiya

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4

Decision: Which side's next forcing pawn contact changes the position first: ...f6, ...b4, h5, or f5?

Memory: The French KIA is a race; count pawn contacts and forcing replies, not board distance.

CARD 2

Black's queenside expansion

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. N1h2 a4

Decision: Does Black's next pawn advance create a threat White must answer, or can White spend that tempo on the king attack?

Memory: Answer a wing move only when it changes the center, opens a file, or attacks something real.

CARD 3

The ...f6 counterbreak

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 f6 11. exf6 Nxf6

Decision: After ...f6, which recapture activates White's pieces, and is the black king safer or more exposed?

Memory: When ...f6 arrives, evaluate the opened lines before deciding whether e5 must survive.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
049 Decode: The main French KIA tabiya	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
050 Play: The main French KIA tabiya	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
051 Decode: Black's queenside expansion	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
052 Play: Black's queenside expansion	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
053 Decode: The ...f6 counterbreak	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
054 Play: The ...f6 counterbreak	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.